

THE HEART OF ALWAYS: A critic

“It reeked of love”—and I don’t mean that negatively.

The book is filled with emotional moments—love not just in the romantic sense, but in loyalty, sacrifice, and familial bonds. I appreciated how the story gave space for softer, more relaxed moments between characters. It was refreshing to see them share jokes, unwind, and simply be themselves — this added a relatable and heartwarming layer to the narrative.

I found the sudden marriages intriguing. They didn’t drag out in a slow-burn romance style, which was refreshing. Instead, the story gave me what I wanted early on—emotion, resolution, and intimacy—and let me enjoy the ride from there. Watching Jerim grow into a strong, reliable partner for Flower and Flower’s scenes as a WOMAN felt satisfying and real. (This goes for Jasmine and Ri as well.)

I especially loved the addition of Flower to the adventure — her presence brought a tender, calming energy that balanced out the heavier themes. Grrrid was another standout — fun, knowledgeable, and just the kind of character who adds spark to every scene he’s in.

You can imagine my shock when it was announced that Jasmine was carrying. I literally cried during those scenes, along with all the other emotional moments—especially those involving Juliard. I can only imagine how hard everything has been for her and her husband. When he thought she had died and mourned, my eyes turned into a waterfall.

Additionally, I found the identity of Lier as an elf uncomfortable, since he was clearly established as a dwarf in the first book. To maintain consistency with the trilogy, I changed Lier back to a dwarf and also adjusted his brother and his brother’s wife, Juliard, to be dwarves as well. This correction keeps the continuity intact and avoids confusing returning readers.

If there was one thing I wished for more of, it would be the action or fight scenes. While the story was rich in character and setup, I was expecting a bit more action along the journey itself. Still, the concept and the looming sense of a larger, darker event give the story an exciting edge. The idea of destiny, evil legacies, and fractured loyalties made it feel like the start of something big.

That said, since this installment is about The Heart of Always, I understand the intent— it focused more on retrieving the heart of always (the dagger) and Always as the daughter of the Opposer, and that made sense thematically.

The ending was a strong cliffhanger, and I think that’s a smart technique since it leaves readers excited and wanting more, which is perfect for a continuing series.

Overall, it was a wonderful and engaging read. The emotional layers, character dynamics, and thoughtful pacing make it a memorable part of the series.

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